Summary Post

Based on my first post, peer feedback and Unit 1, 2 and 3 content, I now recognise that data and digital technologies can amplify and distort human rights investigations. While tools like satellite images, artificial intelligence and digital evidence gathering enable investigators to spot abuses in hard-to-reach areas, they can also skew results by creating bias, privacy risks and accountability issues. One major insight from Hancock et al. (2024) is the risk of a “false sense of bright spots”, where areas with better digital presence get more scrutiny, while violations in data-sparse areas go unnoticed. As Kaona Hoxha pointed out in her feedback, a lack of digital evidence does not mean that no human rights abuses took place. Therefore, investigators should record data limitations and unknowns, and use digital evidence in conjunction with interviews, community groups and conventional investigation techniques (Koenig et al., 2021).

Mohammed Ahmed, Abinel Madzivire and Kaona Hoxha’s comments highlighted the value of independent algorithmic audits, human oversight and clear data governance. It is critical to maintain accountability at every stage of the information lifecycle to safeguard the privacy and safety of victims and witnesses. I also now understand the importance of community engagement in the development of technological tools. Engaging the communities most impacted by issues such as discrimination in system design, testing, and consent over how data is used may help mitigate harm and create solutions that are truly relevant.

In conclusion, I believe that technology must be transparent, ethical and accountable. In my future work, I will advocate for community engagement, independent oversight and a human-centric approach in order to ensure that

technology does not pose additional risks to victims and witnesses, or entrench inequality in human rights investigations.

References:

- Hancock, J., Hui, R., Singh, J. and Mazumder, A. (2024) Trouble at Sea: Data and Digital Technology Challenges for Maritime Human Rights Concerns. In: Proceedings of the 2024 ACM Conference on Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency (FAccT '24).
- Koenig, A., Irving, E., McDermott, Y. and Murray, D. (2021) 'New Technologies and the Investigation of International Crimes', Journal of International Criminal Justice, 19(1), pp. 1–7.